

SMM Iron Ore Daily

2026-09-30 Wednesday · Imported & Domestic Ore · Prices · Supply-Demand · Inventory · Commentary

Source SMM Data-pro

Futures Contracts

Closing price

SGX Iron Ore Most-traded Contract Daily

94.86 USD/dmt

▼ -0.45 -0.47%

MTD avg 97.34

As of Sep 29 · vs Sep 28

DCE Iron Ore Most-traded I2701 Daily

702.5 yuan/mt

▲ +3.5 +0.50%

MTD avg 717.4

SMM Iron Ore Price Index

All five MMi as of Sep 30 · vs Sep 29

MMi 61% Port Spot Daily

674 yuan/wmt

▲ +1 +0.15%

MTD avg 692

MMi 58% Port Spot Daily

638 yuan/wmt

— 0 0.00%

MTD avg 647

MMi 65% Port Spot Daily

838 yuan/wmt

▲ +2 +0.24%

MTD avg 840

MMi 61% Seaborne Index Daily

94.20 USD/dmt

▲ +0.15 +0.16%

MTD avg 96.51

MMi 65% Seaborne Index Daily

112.00 USD/dmt

▲ +0.05 +0.04%

MTD avg 114.43

SMM Domestic Ore Composite Index Daily

831.59 yuan/mt

▼ -5.86 -0.70%

MTD avg 840.09

Index as of Sep 24 · vs Sep 23

Key View

Prices bounced modestly on the last session before the holiday, but hot metal fell a fourth straight week with the decline widening, and SMM already warns of a markedly sharper drop in early October

Today's prices and today's data point in opposite directions. On prices: the DCE most-traded contract **reclaimed 700 at 702.5 yuan/mt** (+0.50%), Qingdao port spot rose **2 yuan** across the board except for flat IOCJ, and the port spot indices had the 65% up 2 yuan, the 61% up 1 and the 58% unchanged. On data: **daily average hot metal across 242 mills fell to 2.3882 million mt** (-6,100 mt WoW), with the blast furnace operating rate at 88.57% and capacity utilisation at 88.15%. Laying out the full path makes the direction much clearer: 2.4080 (Sep 2 peak) → 2.4028 → 2.3991 → 2.3943 → 2.3882 million mt — **four consecutive weekly declines, 19,800 mt off the peak, with the last three drops widening from 3,700 to 4,800 to 6,100 mt**. Demand is not bottoming; the contraction is accelerating. More important, SMM has now given explicit forward guidance: **with mills loss-making, some report they will draw up maintenance plans in early October and overall hot metal output may fall markedly**. Combined with maintenance losses projected to reach 1.6839 million mt next week (a further +55,100 mt), the first post-holiday hot metal print could well be the largest decline of this cycle. Margins move the same way: the average imported ore loss widened from 5.08 to **6.12 yuan/mt**, and SMM expects further widening. One basis tension should be stated plainly, though — that table references Sep 29 spot and freight, whereas on Sep 30 port spot recovered and freight fell another 4–6%, both of which mechanically repair margins; the first print after the holiday could recover some ground. Two structural shifts are worth recording. First, **freight's accelerating collapse**: C3 has slid from 43.06 to 40.26 and C5 from 16.36 to 14.13, two-day falls of 6.5% and 13.6%. The support argument that high Brazilian freight was curbing shipments is now void, and the room for Brazilian supply to recover only grows. Second, **coke supply is recovering**: coke oven capacity utilisation rose to 75.0% this week (+2.3 ppt) and Shanxi to 72.7% (+2.8 ppt) — the practical precondition for the rumoured first round of price cuts, and currently the only thread pointing to demand repair. On balance, the pre-holiday bounce is sentiment repair and does not change a **soft and choppy** picture. The first trading week of October turns on two things: how large the hot metal decline actually is, and whether the coke cut lands. The first sets the slope of the decline; the second decides whether it has an end.

Today's Highlights

◆ **Hot metal fell for a fourth straight week, and the decline keeps widening.** SMM's survey of 242 mills puts daily average hot metal output at **2.3882 million mt** on Sep 30, down 6,100 mt WoW, with the blast furnace operating rate at 88.57% (-0.19 ppt) and capacity utilisation at 88.15% (-0.18 ppt). Output has now fallen for four consecutive weeks since peaking at 2.4080 million mt on Sep 2, with the weekly drop widening from 3,700 to 4,800 to **6,100 mt**.

◆ **SMM's warning: A October could open with a "markedly sharper" fall in hot metal.** Two blast furnaces went down for maintenance this period (Hebei and Liaoning) against two restarts, but SMM's outlook is explicit: **with mills loss-making, some report they will draw up maintenance plans in early October, and overall hot metal output may fall markedly**. It is the most direct downgrade to post-holiday demand yet.

◆ **A modest bounce on the last session before the holiday.** The DCE most-traded I2701 settled at **702.5 yuan/mt** (+3.5 yuan, +0.50%), back above 700, and Qingdao port spot rose **2 yuan/wmt across the board** except for flat IOCJ. But SGX (as of Sep 29) was down 0.47% at USD 94.86/dmt and all five MMi indices stopped falling: the seaborne 61% rose to USD 94.20/dmt (+0.16%) and the 65% to USD 112.00 (+0.04%). Yet none of the gains reached 0.2%, and SGX (as of Sep 29) was still down 0.47% at USD 94.86/dmt — set against a fourth straight weekly fall in hot metal, this looks like pre-holiday sentiment repair rather than a turn in trend.

◆ **Import losses widened even as freight accelerated lower.** SMM puts the average imported ore loss at **6.12 yuan/mt**, up from 5.08, and expects it to widen further. Freight, meanwhile, kept collapsing: C3 Brazil-China at **USD 40.26/mt** (-4.05%) and C5 Australia-China at **USD 14.13/mt** (-6.11%), both as of Sep 29 — two-day falls of 6.5% and 13.6% respectively.

Qingdao Port Imported Ore Spot Prices

yuan/wet mt · tax incl. · 2026-09-29 → 2026-09-30

Product	09-30 (yuan/wmt)	Daily change / %	MTD avg	Last 12 months
PB Fines 60.8% Daily	665	▲ +2 +0.30%	683	
Newman Fines 61.2% Daily	668	▲ +2 +0.30%	688	
Mac Fines 60.8% Daily	667	▲ +2 +0.30%	685	
BRBF 62.5% Daily	720	▲ +2 +0.28%	739	
Newman Lump 63% Daily	860	▲ +2 +0.23%	881	
Super Special Fines (SSF) 56.5% Daily	527	▲ +2 +0.38%	545	
Carajas Fines (IOCJ) 65% Daily	842	— 0 0.00%	845	
PB Lump 61.5% Daily	860	▲ +2 +0.23%	878	

Imported Ore USD Prices & MMi Indices

CFR Qingdao · USD/dry mt

USD prices 2026-09-29 → 2026-09-30

Product	09-30 (USD/dmt)	Daily change / %	MTD avg	Last 12 months
Carajas Fines (IOCJ) 65% Daily	116.54	▲ +0.67 +0.58%	116.14	
PB Lump 61.6% Daily	119.11	▲ +0.67 +0.57%	121.00	
BRBF 62.5% Daily	99.12	▲ +0.66 +0.67%	101.22	
Newman Fines 61.2% Daily	91.69	▲ +0.65 +0.71%	93.96	
Mac Fines 61% Daily	91.55	▲ +1.37 +1.52%	93.49	
Jimblebar Fines 60.5% Daily	89.55	▲ +0.65 +0.73%	90.64	
FMG Blend Fines 58.5% Daily	87.26	▲ +0.65 +0.75%	88.23	
Newman Lump 63% Daily	119.11	▲ +0.67 +0.57%	121.46	
Super Special Fines (SSF) 57% Daily	71.55	▲ +0.63 +0.89%	73.54	
Indian Fines 57% Daily	66.98	▲ +0.63 +0.95%	69.18	

SMM Iron Ore Price Index weekly / monthly statistics

Index	Month-to-date avg	MoM	YTD	Unit	Last 12 months
SMM MMi 61% Iron Ore Seaborne Index Daily	96.51	+1.23%	-11.1%	USD/dmt	
SMM MMi 65% Iron Ore Seaborne Index Daily	114.43	-1.18%	-7.7%	USD/dmt	
SMM MMi 61% Iron Ore Port Spot Index Daily	692	+0.33%	-17.1%	yuan/wmt	
SMM MMi 65% Iron Ore Port Spot Index Daily	840	+0.78%	-6.8%	yuan/wmt	
SMM MMi 58% Iron Ore Port Spot Index Daily	647	+1.30%	-11.1%	yuan/wmt	
SMM China Domestic Ore Composite Price Index Daily	840.09	-0.11%	-6.2%	yuan/mt	

All five indices stopped falling: the 65% port spot rose 2 yuan to 838, the 61% 1 yuan to 674 and the 58% held at 638, widening the high-low spread from 198 to **200 yuan/wmt**; on the seaborne side the 61% rose to USD 94.20/dmt (+0.16%) and the 65% to USD 112.00 (+0.04%), both ending their losing runs. None of the gains reached 0.2%, however, and against a fourth straight weekly decline in hot metal and widening import losses the indices show no trend reversal — this reads as pre-holiday sentiment repair.

* SMM quotations for Newman Fines and PB Lump (both CNY and USD) start in Mar 2026; their sparklines cover that shorter window only. All others show the past year.

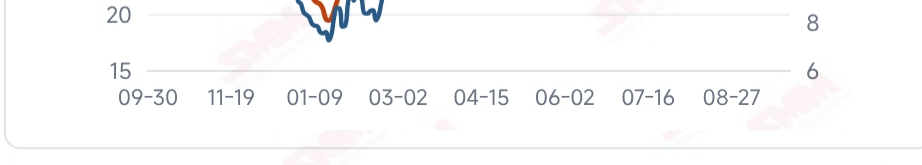
Key Price Drivers

Last 12 months

Iron Ore Ocean Freight

USD/mt · last 12M · daily · C3 Tubarao→Beilun/Baoshan, C5 W. Australia Dampier→Qingdao/Beilun/Baoshan

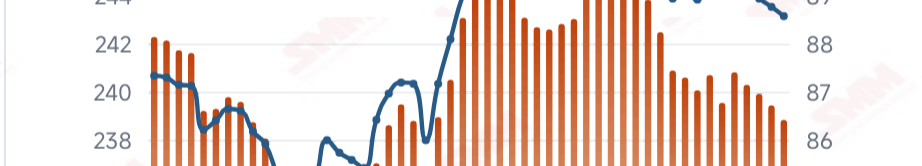
C3 Brazil→China C5 Australia→China



Daily Avg Hot Metal Output & BF Operating Rate, 242 Mills

Left: 10,000 mt Right: % · weekly

Daily avg hot metal (242) BF operating rate (242)



Global Iron Ore Shipments vs Arrivals at Chinese Ports

10,000 mt · weekly · shipments 123 ports · arrivals 61 ports

Global shipments (123 ports) Arrivals at Chinese ports (61 ports)



Market Commentary · Imported Ore

Futures & spot Broad gains on the final session before the holiday. The DCE most-traded I2701 settled at 702.5 yuan/mt, up 3.5 yuan (+0.50%) from Sep 29 and back above 700; SGX most-traded was USD 94.86/dmt (as of Sep 29, -0.47%). Qingdao port spot on SMM's basis rose 2 yuan/wmt across the board: PB Fines 665, Newman Fines 668, Mac Fines 667, BRBF 720, Newman Lump 860, SSF 527 and PB Lump 860 yuan/wmt; **only IOCJ was unchanged, at 842 yuan/wmt. Basis note:** the DCE change is computed on closing prices (699.0 → 702.5); SGX and the all five MMi indices are updated through Sep 30, while SGX and ocean freight are as of Sep 29, one day behind the spot basis.

Drivers Both sides advanced a step. Bullish: talk of a first round of coke price cuts is still live, and **coke oven capacity utilisation recovered to 75.0% this week** (+2.3 ppt) and **Shanxi at 72.7% (+2.8 ppt)** — recovering coke supply is precisely what makes a price cut feasible; the two-day slide in freight is also pulling landed costs down. Bearish: **hot metal fell for a fourth week with the decline widening**, and SMM now warns that early-October maintenance planning will bring a markedly sharper fall. SMM's overall call is unchanged: **iron ore lacks bullish support and prices should stay soft and choppy near term**.

Demand **The key numbers this issue.** On Sep 30 SMM's 242-mill survey showed daily average hot metal at 2.3882 million mt (-6,100 mt WoW), the blast furnace operating rate at 88.57% (-0.19 ppt) and capacity utilisation at 88.15% (-0.18 ppt). Laid out in full, the path reads 2.4080 (Sep 2 peak) → 2.4028 → 2.3991 → 2.3943 → **2.3882 million mt**: four consecutive weekly declines, 19,800 mt off the peak, with the last three drops of 3,700, 4,800 and 6,100 mt **widening each week**. Two furnaces entered maintenance (Hebei, Liaoning) against two restarts — a structural reshuffle. The real signal is in the outlook: **with mills loss-making, some say they will draw up maintenance plans in early October and overall hot metal output may fall markedly**. Maintenance losses were not updated this issue and still read 1.6288 million mt for this week (Sep 26-Oct 2) and 1.6839 million for next (Oct 3–9), per the Sep 28 survey.

Inventory & supply No new weekly supply data this issue: arrivals in China remain 294625 million mt (-5.93% WoW) and global shipments 35,5121 million mt (+3.21%) from the Sep 28 survey, while port stocks stand at 145,45 million mt across 35 ports as of Sep 25 (+1.12 million mt WoW) and 102,594 million mt across 10 ports as of Sep 24 (+681,500 mt). Two supply-side items are new. First, **Australia's big three published their October discounts, which diverge by product**. Second, **the Brazilian freight constraint has broken down further**: C3 has slid from 43.06 to 40.26, so the earlier argument that high freight was curbing shipments from smaller miners no longer holds, and the room for Brazilian shipments to recover keeps opening up.

Cost & margin SMM puts the average imported ore loss at **6.12 yuan/mt, up modestly from 5.08**, mainly on the slight decline in spot prices, and expects **losses on imported ore to widen further**. Freight fell sharply again: C3 Brazil-China at USD 40.26/mt (-4.05%) and C5 Australia-China at USD 14.13/mt (-6.11%), both as of Sep 29 — two-day falls of 6.5% and 13.6%, with C5 now USD 3.64 below its Sep 14 level of 17.77. **One tension between basis and mechanics is worth flagging**: the table was published on the morning of Sep 14 and references Sep 29 costs and realisations, whereas on Sep 30 port spot rose 1–2 yuan and freight fell another 4–6% — both of which point to margin repair (the seaborne index rose USD 0.15/dmt the same day, which roughly offsets the port spot gain). SMM's "losses may widen further" is a forward call premised on soft ore prices; the first post-holiday print could well recover some ground.

Market Commentary · Domestic Ore

Prices SMM's brief turned to eastern Liaoning today: **local domestic ore prices showed no clear movement**, with both sides trading cautiously. The SMM China Domestic Ore Composite Price Index stands at 831.59 yuan/mt (as of Sep 24, -0.70%), with no new print this issue. On a monthly basis, **national iron ore concentrate output was 18.87 million mt in September 2026**.

Supply & demand Supply: sales are **mostly against long-term contracts, and supply remains generally tight**; holders' costs are high and their willingness to sell cheaply is thin, which supports prices. That said, **some concentrators are struggling to move material and a few have accepted low bids under inventory pressure**, a subtle but meaningful drag. Demand: mill operations are relatively stable and **demand resilience is still decent** — a contrast with the falling hot metal on the imported ore side, explained by domestic concentrate demand coming largely from comparatively steady regional contract buyers. Weekly data were not updated and still read a 58.1% mine capacity utilisation rate (-0.01 ppt) and 898,000 mt of concentrate output (-2,000 mt) as of Sep 25.

Outlook SMM expects **local iron ore prices in eastern Liaoning to trade range-bound near term**. Set against last issue's "soft and choppy" call for Tangshan, eastern Liaoning is holding up better on tight supply and a high share of contract volumes — regional divergence is widening. Watch after the holiday for whether individual concentrators' inventory pressure shifts over.

Market Factors

▲ Supportive factors

- The DCE reclaimed 700 at 702.5 yuan/mt on the last session before the holiday; Qingdao spot rose 2 yuan/wmt.

- Talk of a first round of coke price cuts in early October persists, easing mill cost pressure.

- Coke oven capacity utilisation recovered to 75.0% this week (+2.3 ppt), making a coke cut feasible.

- C3 and C5 fell 6.5% and 13.6% over two days, pulling landed costs lower.

- Eastern Liaoning supply is tight, sales are contract-led, and holders' costs are high.

- The 65% port spot index rose 2 yuan, widening the high-low spread from 198 to 200 yuan/wmt.

▼ Bearish factors

- Hot metal fell a fourth straight week to 2.3882 million mt, with drops widening 3,700 → 4,800 → 6,100 mt.

- SMM warns some mills will set maintenance plans in early October, with hot metal possibly falling markedly.

- The average imported ore loss widened from 5.08 to 6.12 yuan/mt, and SMM expects further widening.

- Maintenance losses are projected at 1.6839 million mt next week (Oct 3–9), up another 55,100 mt.

- Softer freight opens room for Brazilian shipments to recover, pushing supply pressure into the post-holiday period.

- Port stocks remain in a build phase, with both the 35-port and 10-port series up last period.

Flash News

Last 2 days · click to open

- [SMM BF Operating Rate] Weaker mill production appetite as hot metal output keeps sliding (2.3882 million mt, -6,100 mt WoW)
- SMM Imported Iron Ore Cost & Margin Table, Sep 30, 2026 (average loss 5.08 → 6.12 yuan/mt)
- [SMM Domestic Iron Ore Brief] Eastern Liaoning iron ore prices set to trade range-bound
- SMM Imported Ore Miner Discounts — October 2026 (Australia's big three diverge by product)
- China's National Iron Ore Concentrate Output, September 2026: 18.87 million mt
- Ocean Freight and Dry Bulk Shipping Indices, Sep 29 (C3 USD 40.26, C5 USD 14.13/mt)

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